bourgeois feminism … The new Hindu woman is therefore, a person with professional and economic opportunities, secure property ownership, legal rights to ensure them and some amount of political power to enforce these rights.' Even on specific questions of gender, when Sarkar studied issues of *Jagruti* (the magazine of the RSS's women's wing) and spoke to office-bearers, she found that the verdict was 'unequivocally modernist'. As she summed it up, this manifestation and celebration of woman power by the Hindu Right paradoxically empowered many women, giving them a public role, 'even leadership', a 'recognition as full-fledged citizens' and 'access to serious intellectual cognition'.[61] In other words, many Hindu nationalist women were independent actors. They did not believe in Western or Leftist notions of feminism and, paradoxically, were not that different from Leftist feminists themselves. Except for one big difference: their political beliefs came from the opposite end of the spectrum.

While the Ayodhya movement drew in committed Hindu nationalist women to the BJP, its overall support base was still largely male-based. By the mid-1990s, it started fronting elected women representatives in legislatures and executive bodies. Its record on this was already 'far better than that of the Left', as Sarkar noted. Yet, the BJP's growth was also simultaneously limited by the patriarchal gender blinkers of many of its own leaders. Despite the Ayodhya spurt, even as late as 1999, Leftist women's outfits like the All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA) had much deeper organisational roots nationally.[62] While the BJP had built a core ideological group of female supporters after the temple movement, the vast majority of Indian women had not begun voting for the party. After the highs of the Ayodhya movement and the Vajpayee era of coalition governments in the 1990s, female support for the BJP remained static through the early 2000s. It started rising sharply in 2009, but election data shows that the real upward shift came with Modi in 2014, and finally in 2019 (see Table 17.2).

Why More Women Moved to the BJP after 2014: Three Strategies for Walking the Talk